



Talanoa Staff Guide

tah-lah-NOH-ah · Tongan for *talking together*

A picture board that speaks. A resident taps a picture and the phone says the words out loud.



Scan to open Talanoa

<https://tcdeveloper27.github.io/Talanoa/>

Made for the residents of Faleofaz

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1 What Talanoa is

Talanoa helps a person who can't speak tell you what they want, how they feel, and who they want to see. It was made for the residents of Faleofaz.

It works like a set of talking picture cards on a phone (or a tablet). Every picture says a short sentence out loud in a natural voice, for example the carrot picture says *"I want a snack."* The words also appear in big letters at the top, so you can read them from across the room, and the picture that said them glows for 30 seconds.

There are 16 pages with 173 pictures in total, plus six important buttons that are always on screen.

Three promises the app keeps

- **It never stays silent.**
If a voice recording can't play, the phone's own voice says it instead.
- **The top row never moves.**
Its six buttons are always in the same place, so they can be found without looking.
- **It works without internet**
once it has been set up.
- **Nothing a resident knows ever moves.**
New words only fill empty spots, and new pages go at the end.

2 Setting up a phone

You only do this once per phone (a tablet works the same way). It takes about two

minutes and needs Wi-Fi.

1

Open Google Chrome

Use Chrome, not a preview from email or Google Drive.

2

Go to the Talanoa address

Scan the QR code on the front of this guide with the phone's camera, or type

tcdeveloper27.github.io/Talanoa
(capital T in Talanoa).

3

Tap the **⋮** menu (three dots, top right)

Choose **Add to Home screen** or **Install app**, then confirm.

4

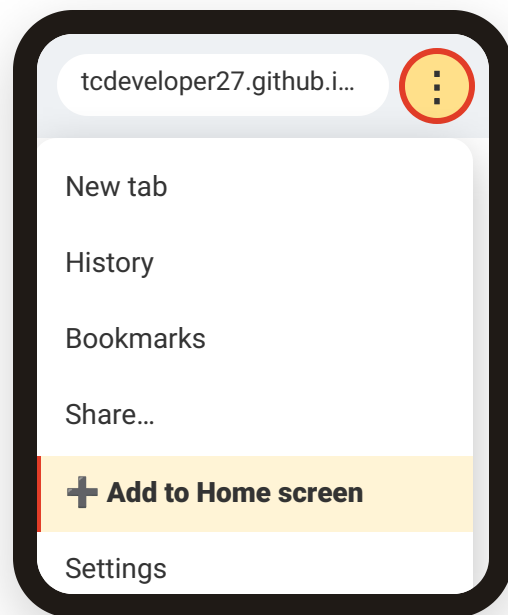
Open Talanoa from its new icon

It opens full screen like any other app.

5

Leave it on Wi-Fi for a minute

It saves the pictures and voice onto the phone. Check in Settings:
Status should say **✓ Ready to use with no internet**.



Step 3 (illustration). The menu on your phone may look a little different.



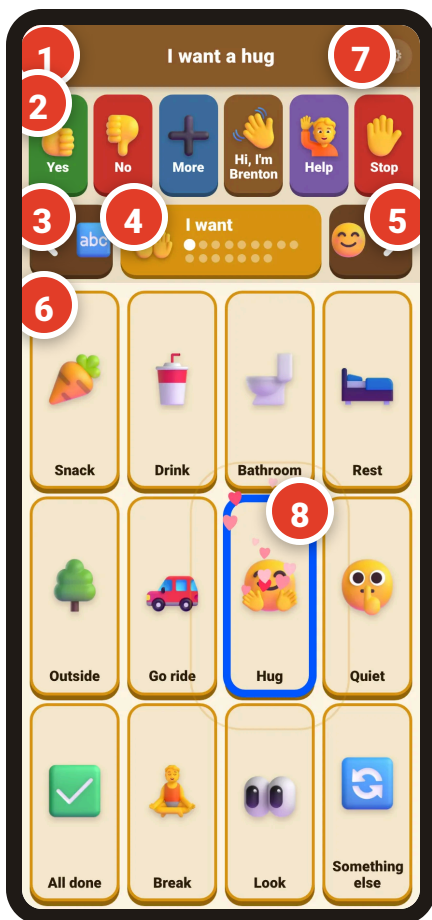
Step 4 (illustration). The Talanoa icon on the home screen.

Tip

Turn the media volume up with the side buttons, and set the screen to stay on longer (see section 17).

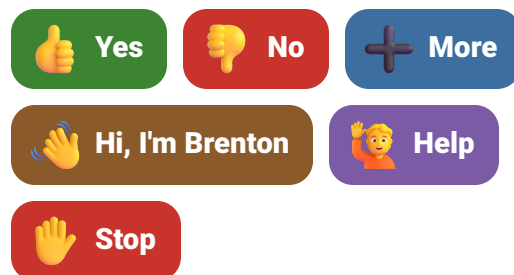
3 The screen at a glance

This is exactly what residents see. The numbers match the list below.



1 Spoken words. Shows what was just said, in big letters, so staff can read it too. It flashes green on every tap, and goes back to "Tap a picture to talk" after 30 seconds. **Tap the words to show them full screen** (section 8).

2 The six "always" buttons. On every page, never moving:



3 Back arrow ◀. Goes to the previous page. The small picture shows which page it goes to.

4 Page name. Shows which page you're on; the dots show where you are in the pages. **Tap it to see all pages at once.**

5 Next arrow ▶. Goes to the next page. After the last page it goes back to the first.

6 Picture tiles. 12 per page, always in the same spots. Tap one to speak. Swipe sideways across them to turn the page.

7 Settings ⚙️. For staff only. It opens only when you **press and hold it for one second**, so residents won't open it by accident.

8

The glow. The last picture tapped glows for 30 seconds, so the resident can lift the phone and show you what they said. Tapping another picture moves the glow to it.

It stays upright

Opened from its home-screen icon, Talanoa stays upright even when the phone is turned sideways, so the pictures stay big.

4 Talking with it

Tap a picture once and the phone says the words.



One tap = one sentence

No double-tapping needed. A tap still counts if the finger slides a little or rests on the picture for a while.



Tap again to repeat

It starts again from the beginning.



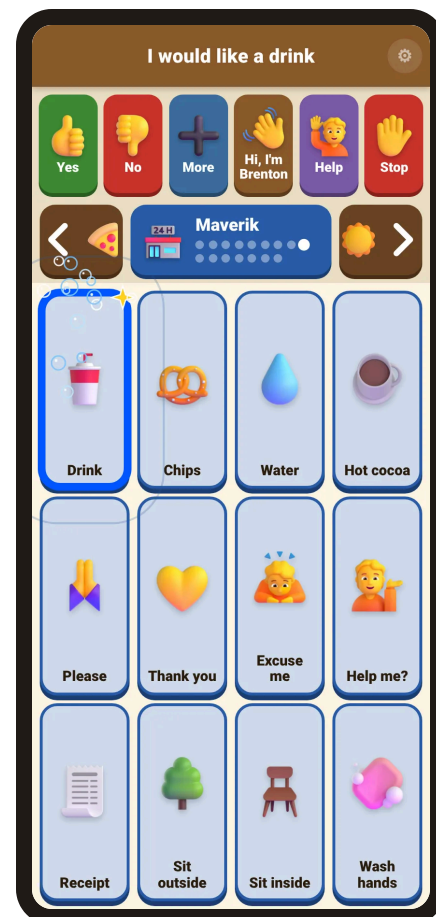
Quick taps are fine

A new tap stops the last sentence and says the new one. Nothing gets stuck.



A little buzz

The phone vibrates slightly on each tap, if it can.



On the **Maverik** page, after tapping **Drink**. The top says "I would like a drink", and Drink glows.



Show someone

The picture glows for 30 seconds, long enough to lift the phone and show a person what was said.



It's fun on purpose

Every tap makes the picture bounce and throws sparkles: confetti for happy words, hearts for hugs, stars on the Toy Story page, bubbles for drinks. Tapping the same picture a few times in a row sets off a shower. Sad or hurt words get just a few gentle sparkles. It's only decoration and never gets in the way of a tap. It can be turned down or off in Settings, and **Calm answers** there gives Yes, No and every feeling the same gentle sparkles, so nobody picks an answer just for the show.

5 Moving between pages

Use the big ◀▶ arrows to flip through the pages, like turning the pages of a book, or swipe sideways across the pictures.



Swipe to turn the page

Slide a finger sideways across the pictures, like on a phone's home screen. The page follows the finger; let go early and it springs back. A swipe never says anything.



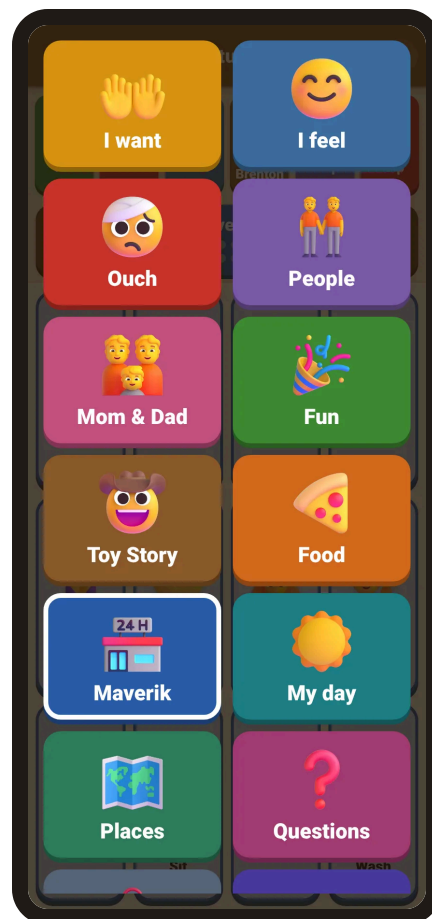
Or tap the arrows

Each arrow shows a small picture of the page it goes to. After the last page it goes back to the first.



Jump straight to a page

Tap the page name in the middle. All pages appear as big buttons: tap one to go there, or tap **×** **Close**.



Tapping the page name shows every page.

Pages turning by accident?

Swiping can be turned off in Settings. The arrows always work.

The 16 pages, in order



I want

1

12 tiles: Snack, Drink, Bathroom, Rest...



I feel

2

12 tiles: Happy, Excited, Sad, Frustrated...



Ouch

3

12 tiles: Head, Tummy, Throw up, Tooth...



People

4

12 tiles: Family, Staff, Friend, Hi...



Mom & Dad

5

12 tiles: Dad, Call Dad, Dad's house, Dad coming?...



Fun

6

12 tiles: Toy Story, Cartoons, Movie, Costume...



Toy Story

7

12 tiles: Howdy, Bullseye, Infinity, Sky...



Food

8

12 tiles: Hungry, Water, Juice, Milk...



Maverik

9

12 tiles: Drink, Chips, Water, Hot cocoa...



My day

10

12 tiles: Wake up, Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner...



Places

11

12 tiles: Home, My room, Store, Park...



Questions

12

11 tiles: What now?, What's next?, Where to?, Who?...



Things

13

12 tiles: Headphones, Hat, Jacket, Sunglasses...



Talk

14

12 tiles: I like it, Don't like, Again, Wait...



Tongan

15

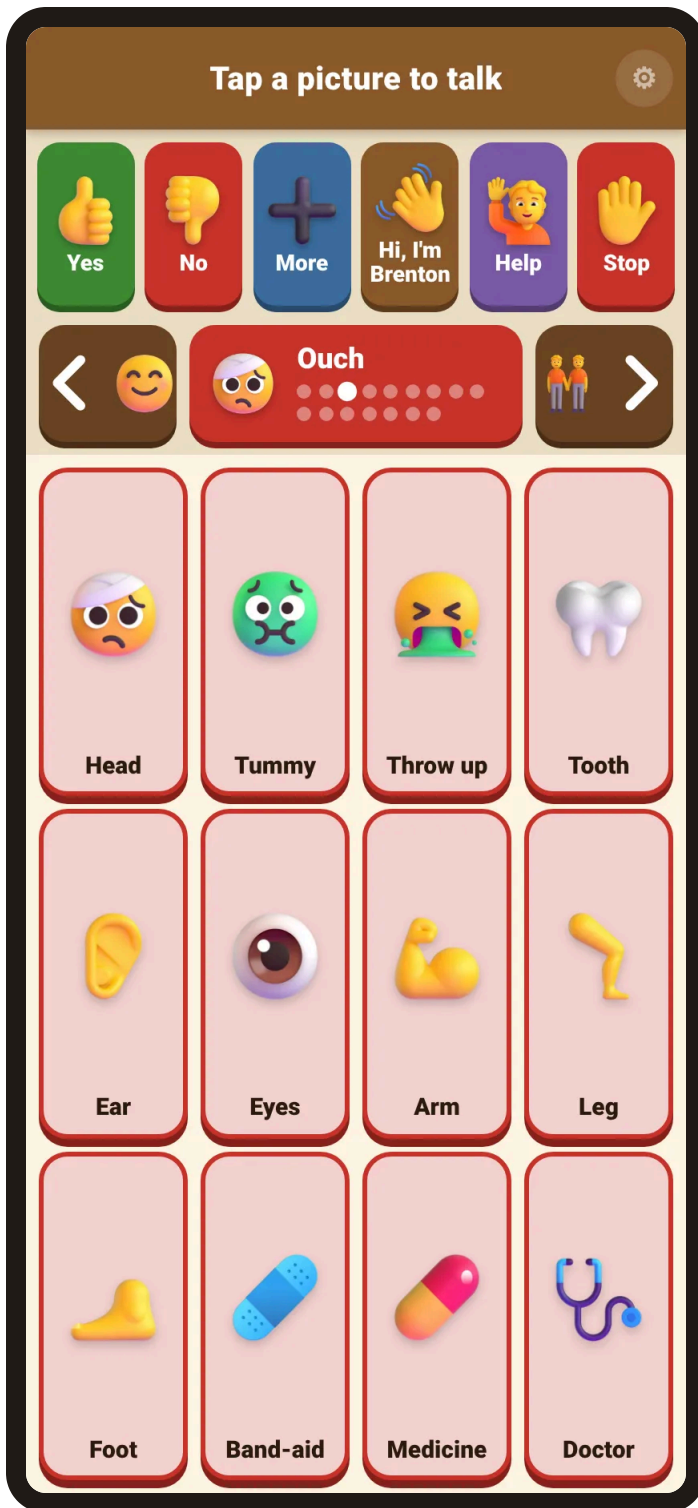
6 tiles: Mālō e lelei, Mālō, Mālō 'aupito, 'Ofa atu...



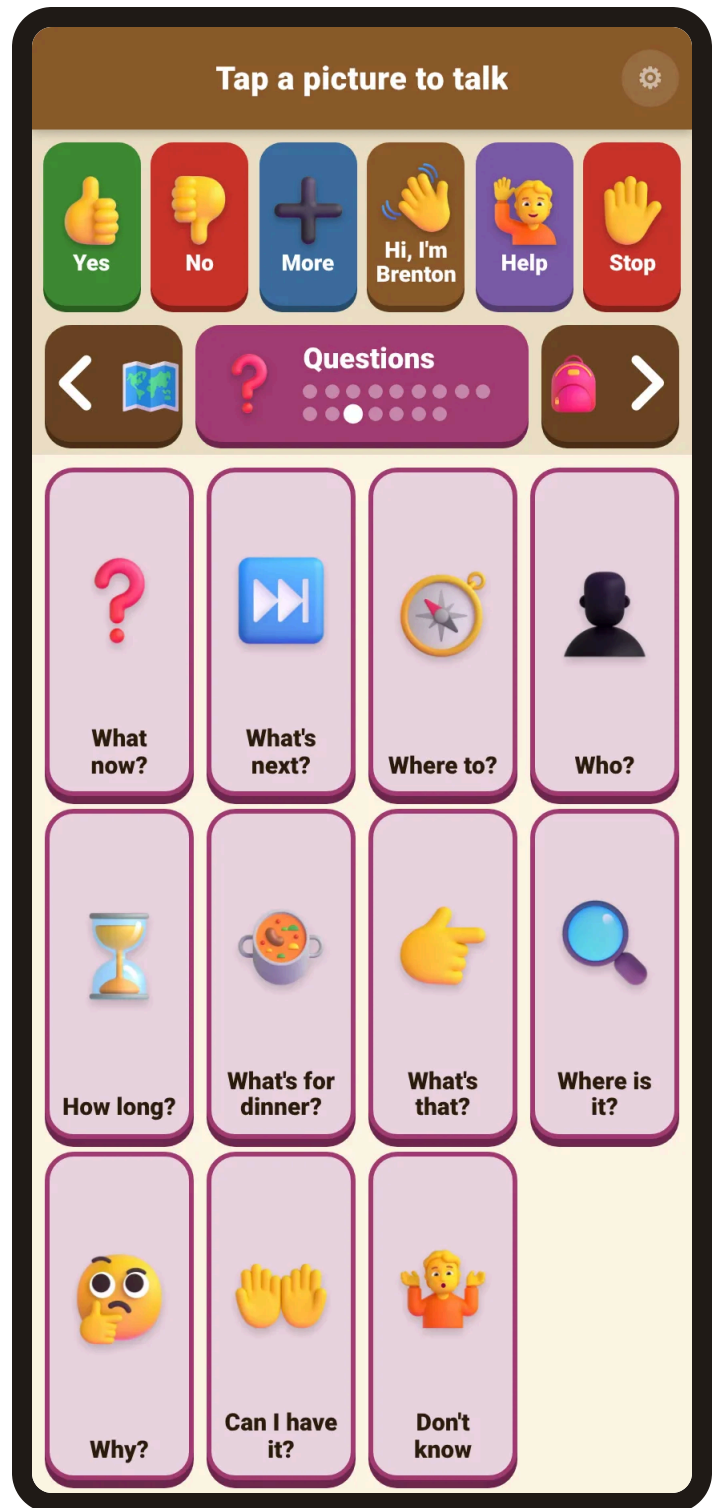
ABC

16

The alphabet: spell a word, then Speak



Ouch: point to where it hurts.



Questions: what's next, where, who, how long.

Pages can be hidden

If a resident doesn't need a page, it can be turned off on that phone in Settings. New pages are always added at the end, so the pages a resident already knows stay the same number of swipes away.

6 The Mom & Dad page

All the parent and grandparent tiles are together on one page.



Every Dad tile has the matching Mom tile **directly underneath it**: Dad and Mom, Call Dad and Call Mom, Dad's house and Mom's house, Dad coming? and Mom coming? The bottom row has Grandma, Grandpa, Nana and Papa.

This layout is deliberate

The family asked that Mom always appears under Dad. The app is built so this can't be changed by accident.

When a resident taps "Call Dad" or "Call Mom"

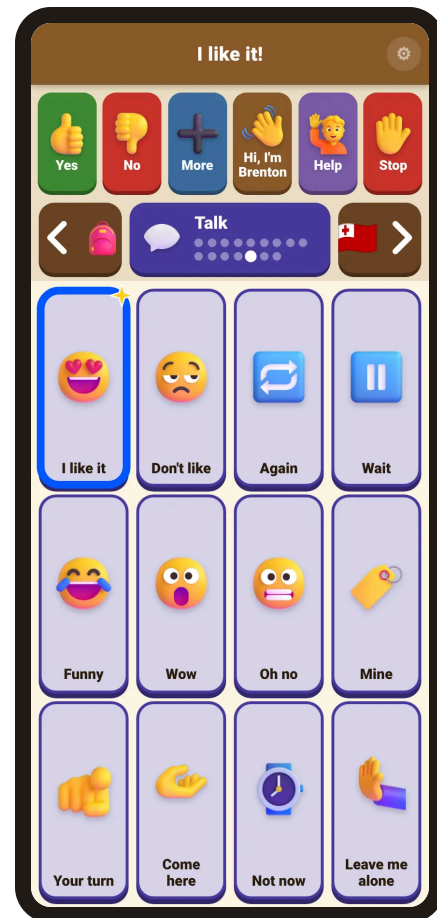
Treat it as a real request: tell them what will happen ("Let's call Mom after lunch") so they know they were heard.

7 The Talk page

Words for saying what they think, not just what they want.

Most of what people say isn't asking for things. It's commenting ("That's funny!"), giving an opinion ("I don't like it"), and steering the conversation ("Wait", "Your turn"). The Talk page gives residents those words too.

Picture	Says
 I like it	"I like it!"
 Don't like	"I don't like it"
 Again	"Again! One more time"
 Wait	"Wait, please"
 Funny	"That's funny!"
 Wow	"Wow!"
 Oh no	"Oh no!"
 Mine	"That's mine"
 Your turn	"Your turn"
 Come here	"Come here, please"
 Not now	"Not now. Maybe later"
 Leave me alone	"Please leave me alone"



The **Talk** page.

"I don't like it", "Not now" and "Leave me alone" are real messages

Honour them whenever you safely can, or say why not: *"Not now? OK. We do have to see the doctor first, then we'll get a drink."* Someone who can say no with words has less need to say it with behaviour.

8 Show it big · About me

For a cashier, a noisy room, someone across the table, or someone new.



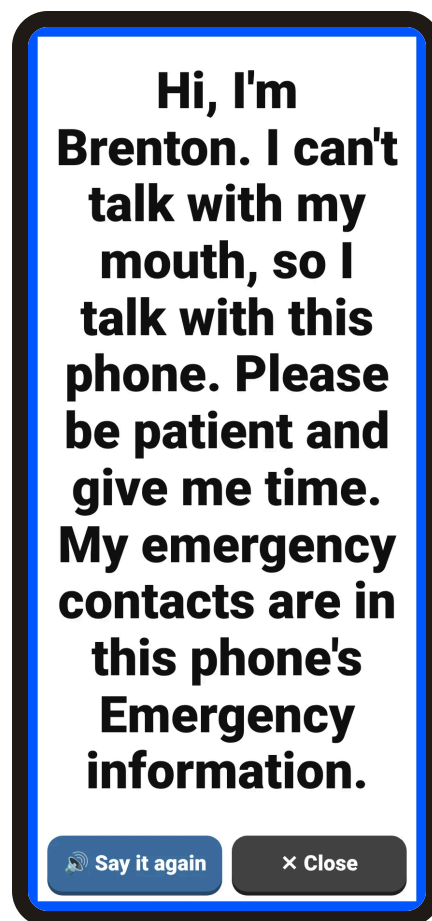
Tap the words at the top

The last thing said fills the screen in giant letters: hold the phone up, or hand it over. 🗣️ **Say it again** repeats it. ✕ **Close** (or Back) goes back to the board, and it closes by itself after a minute.



Hi, I'm Brenton (top row: about me)

Says: *"Hi, I'm Brenton. I can't talk with my mouth, so I talk with this phone. Please be patient and give me time. My emergency contacts are in this phone's Emergency information."* Tap the words at the top to show them big. Use it with anyone new: a driver, a cashier, a doctor, a police officer or a paramedic. The People page has a short **Hi, I'm Brenton** for a quick hello.



After tapping **Hi, I'm Brenton**, then the words at the top.

Opening by accident?

Settings → **Reading** → untick **Tap the words to show them big**.

Set up the phone's Emergency information

The about-me message points to the phone's own **Emergency information**. Paramedics and police know to look there, and they can see it from the lock screen without unlocking the phone. Phone numbers and medical details belong there, not in Talanoa, because the Talanoa website is public.

1

Open the phone's Settings app

The phone's own settings (the gear icon among the apps), not Talanoa's ⚙️.

2

Search for "Emergency"

Open **Emergency information**. On some phones it's called **Medical info**, or it's inside **Safety & emergency** or the **Personal Safety** app.

3

Add medical details and emergency contacts

Conditions, allergies, medicines, and who to call (family, and Faleofaz).

4

Turn on "Show on lock screen"

To check it: lock the phone, swipe up, tap **Emergency**, then **Emergency information**.

9 Tongan words · your own photos and voices

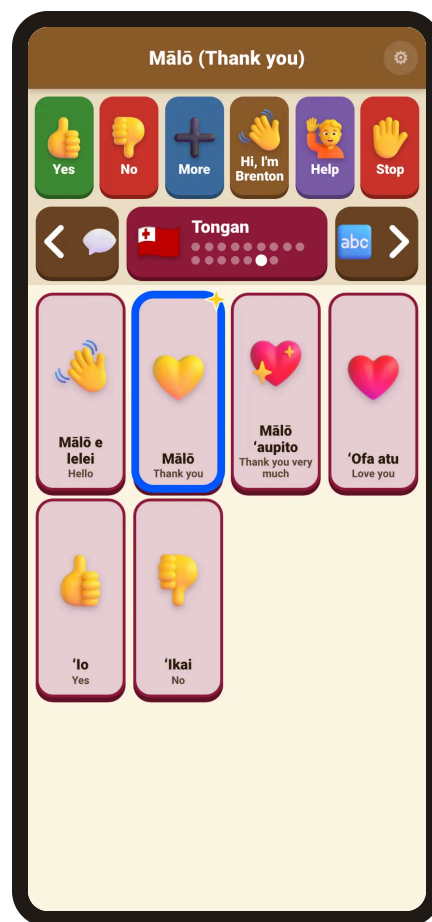
Any picture can show a real photo, and speak in a real person's voice.

The Tongan page

Mālō e lelei (Hello), **Mālō** (Thank you), **Mālō 'aupito** (Thank you very much), **'Ofa atu** (Love you), **'Io** (Yes), **'Ikai** (No). Each tile shows what it means underneath, and the top of the screen shows both.

Please record them in your own voice

The computer voice can't speak Tongan, so for now it only gets close. A recording by someone from Faleofaz will sound right, and mean much more. It takes about a minute per word (steps below). To add more Tongan words, tell Tim (section 18).



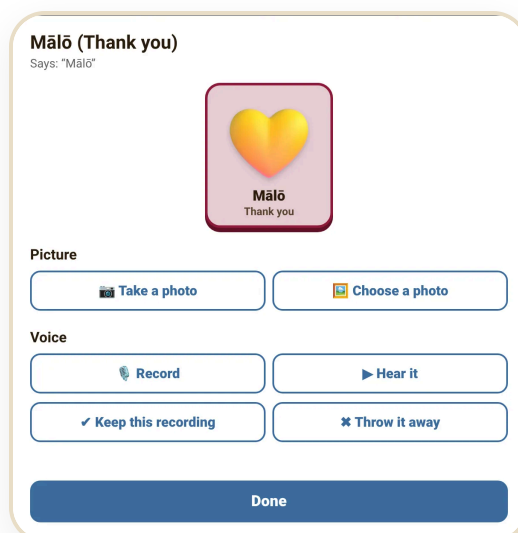
The **Tongan** page.

Record a voice, or add a photo

1

Hold  → **Photos and voices**

Tap   **Change a picture or voice...**



2

Choose the page, then tap the picture

 marks pictures that already have a photo,  ones that have a recording.

3

Record, say the words, then Stop

Find a quiet spot and hold the phone about a hand's width from your mouth. The first time, allow the microphone.

4

Listen, then ✓ Keep this recording

Or ✕ **Throw it away** and try again.
From then on, that picture speaks in your voice.

5

For a photo: Take a photo or Choose a photo

Good for family, staff, a favourite cup, their room, a store they love.

Use the original picture again undoes it.

They're kept on this phone only, so save a backup

Photos and recordings are never put on the website, so photos of people stay private. It also means a new phone, or removing the app, loses them. Now and then, hold ⚙ → **Save a backup** and email the file to yourself or to Tim. **Restore a backup** puts everything back, on any phone.

10 The ABC page

The alphabet, for spelling anything that isn't on a picture.



Tap letters

Each letter says its name. **Space** goes between words,  takes back one letter, **Clear** starts again.



Speak

Says the whole word or sentence, and puts it at the top, where it can be shown big.



The same voice as the pictures

The letters, every word that's on the board and thousands of everyday words are recorded in the chosen voice. A word it doesn't have (often a name) is spelled out, letter by letter, in that same voice.

Not spelling yet? That's fine

Let them explore the letters, and read back what they type. Playing with letters is how spelling starts.



HI MOM, typed on the ABC page.

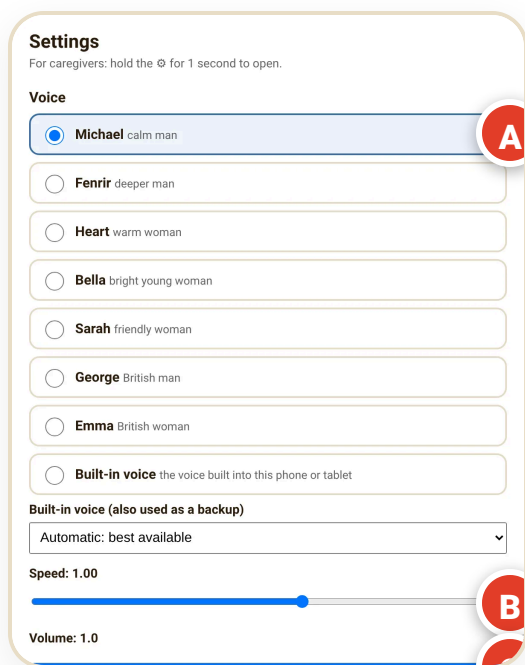
11 Settings

Settings belong to each phone. Changing them on one phone doesn't change any other.



Press and hold the ⚙️ in the top-right corner

Keep your finger on it for 1 second, then let go



A

Voice. Tap a name to choose it. You'll hear "Hi! This is my voice." Choose the one that suits the resident.

B

Speed. Slide left for slower speech, right for faster. 1.00 is normal.

C

Volume. The app's own loudness. Also check the phone's side buttons.

The 7 voices

Voice	Sounds like
Michael default	calm man
Fenrir	deeper man
Heart	warm woman
Bella	bright young woman
Sarah	friendly woman
George	British man
Emma	British woman
Built-in voice	the voice built into the phone or tablet (sound depends on the device)

Pages to show

☒ I want	☒ I feel	☒ Ouch
☒ People	☒ Mom & Dad	☒ Fun
☒ Toy Story	☒ Food	☒ Maverik
☒ My day	☒ Places	☒ Questions
☒ Things	☒ Talk	☒ Tongan
☒ ABC		

Turning pages

☒ **Swipe to change pages** The ◀▶ arrows always work too.

Fun effects

☒ **Lots** bounces, rings, sparkles, confetti, hearts, stars...

☐ **A little** bounces and rings, no sparkles

☐ **Off** just the blue outline

☐ **Calm answers** Yes, No, every feeling and the Talk page all get the same few gentle sparkles, so no answer is more fun to pick than another. Off: they keep the usual sparkles.

Reading

☒ **Tap the words to show them big** Tapping the words at the top fills the screen with them, for a cashier, a noisy room, or someone across the table.

☐ **Darker page names** Darkens the lighter colours a little (I want, Food, Fun, Mom & Dad, Yes) so the white writing is easier to read.

Screen

Screen 632 × 3600, navigation bar 0 px

☐ **Bottom row hidden behind the ◀●■ buttons?** Tick this to move the board

D Pages to show. Untick a page to hide it on this phone; tick it to bring it back. At least one page always stays on.

E Swipe to change pages. On to start with. Untick it if pages turn by accident; the ◀▶ arrows always work.

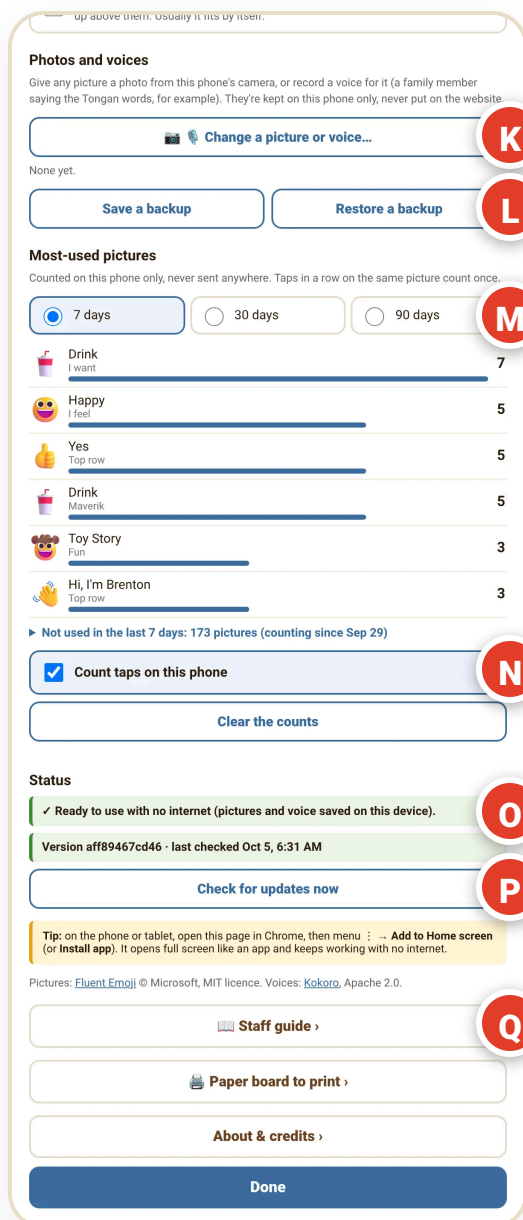
F Fun effects. Lots (bounces, rings and sparkles), **A little** (bounces and rings only) or **Off**. Turn it down if the sparkles distract a resident or the phone feels slow.

G Calm answers. Off to start with. On, Yes, No, every feeling and the Talk page all get the same few gentle sparkles, so nobody picks an answer just for the show.

H Tap the words to show them big. On to start with (section 8). Untick it if the big words keep opening by accident.

I Darker page names. Off to start with. Darkens the lighter page colours a little so the white writing is easier to read.

J Screen. What the phone reported (size, navigation bar). If the bottom row hides behind the ◀●■ buttons, tick **Bottom row hidden...** to move the board up.



K Photos and voices. Give a picture a photo, or record a voice for it (section 9).

L Save a backup · Restore a backup. Keeps this phone's photos and recordings safe in one file, and puts them back.

M Most-used pictures. Which pictures were used most in the last 7, 30 or 90 days; tap the line underneath to see which weren't used at all. Counted on this phone only and never sent anywhere. Use it to see which words matter, and to tell the family what's missing.

N Count taps on this phone · Clear the counts. Counting can be switched off, and the counts cleared.

O Status. "✓ Ready to use with no internet" means everything is saved. Below it you'll see the version and when it last checked for updates.

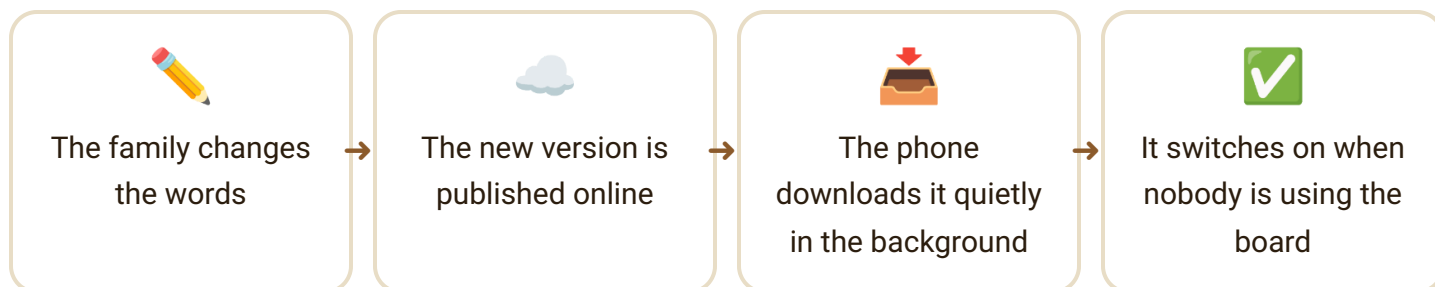
P Check for updates now. Gets the newest version straight away (see section 12).

Q Staff guide · Paper board to print · About & credits. This guide, the paper board (section 15), and who made Talanoa.

Tap **Done** at the bottom to close Settings.

12 Updates

You don't have to do anything. New words and fixes arrive by themselves.



- The phone checks when Talanoa opens, when the screen turns back on, and every 30 minutes.
- It **never changes while someone is tapping**. It waits until nobody has tapped for 2 minutes, or the screen is off, and then comes back on the same page.
- **To update right now:** hold ⚙️ → **Check for updates now**. If there's something new, the app restarts by itself with it.

The message says...	Meaning
✓ You have the latest version.	Nothing to do.
Downloading the new version... the app will restart by itself.	Wait a few seconds.
A new version is ready and will switch on when the board is not in use.	It will update on its own soon.
Could not check: no internet connection right now.	Connect to Wi-Fi and try again. The board still works normally.

13 Without Wi-Fi

Once the phone shows ✓ **Ready to use with no internet**, Talanoa works anywhere: on outings, in the car, at the store, or when the Wi-Fi is down. Pictures, words and the chosen voice are all saved on the phone.

After choosing a new voice

Keep the phone on Wi-Fi for a minute so the new voice can be saved. Until then, any sentence that isn't saved yet uses the phone's own voice. It's never silent.

14 Helping someone talk

The most helpful thing staff can do costs nothing: use the board yourself, every day.



Use the board when you talk to them

As you speak, tap the main word on their board: "Let's go to *Maverik*", "Do you want *more*?" Children hear thousands of hours of talk before they say a word; someone learning a talker needs to see it used the same way. Ask first ("Can I show you on your phone?"), or point to the paper board instead.



Show, don't test

No quizzing ("Show me Drink!"). Just use the words naturally while you talk.



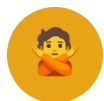
Wait

After a question, count to ten in your head before helping. Finding the right page and picture takes time.



Answer every message, even when the answer is no

"I hear you, you want a drink. We'll get one after lunch." That's how people learn their words work.



No means no

"No", "Stop", "Not now" and "Leave me alone" are real. Respect them whenever you safely can, or explain why not.



Playing with it is learning

Tapping lots of pictures, or the same one again and again, is how people explore their words, the way a baby babbles. Don't stop it: say the words back, and join in.



It's their voice: keep it with them

All day, charged, in every room. **Never take the board away** as a punishment or to get someone to behave.



Notice what's missing

Settings → **Most-used pictures** shows which words get used. When someone seems to want a word that isn't there, tell the family.

Everyone has the right to communicate

The Communication Bill of Rights (ASHA, 3rd edition, 2024) lists twelve rights. They include: to be treated with dignity and respect; to communicate in a way that fits their culture and language; to be spoken to directly, not talked about; to get a response to every message, even when the answer is no; to ask for things and to refuse them; to share feelings, comments and opinions; to make real choices; and to have a working talker with them at all times. asha.org/njc/communication-bill-of-rights

Free training

Project Core has 12 short, free training modules on teaching with a talker. They're made for schools, but the ideas work at any age.

Talanoa supports, it doesn't replace

Talanoa is a simple, friendly board, not a full professional speech system. A speech-language pathologist who specializes in AAC can suggest what each resident needs.

15 The paper board

Every page on paper, in the same colours and places as on the phone.

For when the phone is charging, lost or broken;
for the shower, the bath, the pool or the rain;
and to point to words while you talk.

1

Print it

Hold ⚙️ → 🖨️ **Paper board to print**, then 🖨️ **Print**. Or print the ready-made PDF: [Talanoa-Paper-Board.pdf](#). Card stock is best.

2

Laminate the sheets

Keep them on a ring, in the same order as the phone's pages: one set in their bag, one at home.

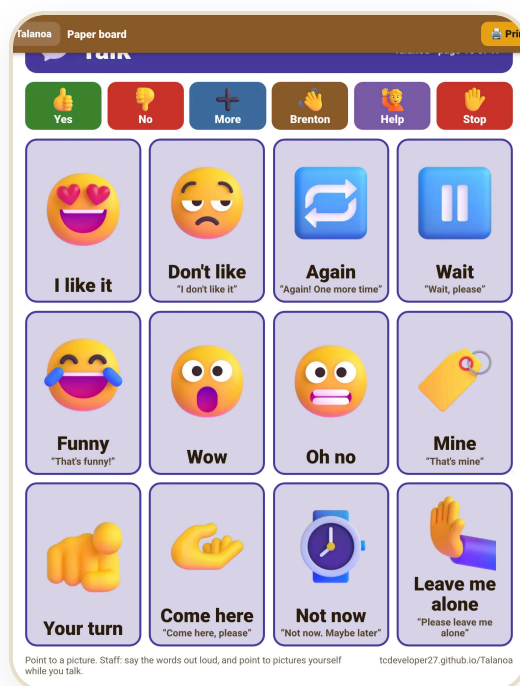
3

Cut out the About me card

It's on the cover. Keep it in a wallet or bag.

Photos too

Opened on the resident's own phone, the paper board uses the photos saved on that phone.



One sheet: the top row, then the page, with each picture's words underneath.

16 If something goes wrong

What you notice

What to do

No sound at all	Turn the volume up with the phone's side buttons. Check the phone isn't on silent. In Settings, check Volume isn't low.
The voice sounds robotic	In Settings, Built-in voice is probably chosen. Choose Michael (or another named voice).
Only a brown bar, no pictures	It was opened in a preview (from email or Google Drive). Open Talanoa from its home-screen icon, or in Chrome.
A page is missing	Settings → Pages to show → tick it.
Settings won't open	Press and hold the ⚙ for a full second. A quick tap does nothing, on purpose.
New words from the family aren't showing	Connect to Wi-Fi, then Settings → Check for updates now .
"404 / There isn't a GitHub Pages site here"	The address was typed wrong. Use the QR code, or type tcdeveloper27.github.io/Talanoa with a capital T.
The ► arrow (or a swipe) jumped back to "I want"	That's normal: after the last page it starts again at the first.
Pages keep turning by accident	Settings → untick Swipe to change pages . The ◀▶ arrows still work.
A picture is glowing	That's the last picture tapped. It stops glowing by itself after 30 seconds, or as soon as another picture is tapped.
Too many sparkles, or the phone feels slow	Settings → Fun effects → A little or Off .
The words suddenly filled the whole screen	That's Show it big (section 8). Tap ✕ Close or Back; it also closes by itself after a minute. To stop it opening by accident: Settings → Reading → untick Tap the words to show them big .

"The microphone is blocked" when recording	Long-press the Talanoa icon → App info → Permissions → Microphone → Allow , then try again.
A photo or recording has disappeared	They're kept on the phone only. Hold ⚙ → Restore a backup and pick the backup file.
The Tongan words don't sound right	The computer voice can't speak Tongan. Record them in a real voice (section 9).
The ABC page spells a word out instead of saying it	It says the words on the board and thousands of everyday words; any other word (often a name) is spelled out in the same voice. To have a word added, tell Tim (section 18).
The bottom row is hidden behind the phone's ◀ • ■ buttons	Close Talanoa and open it again (it fits itself to the phone the first time). If it's still hidden: Settings → Screen → tick Bottom row hidden behind the ◀ • ■ buttons?
The screen keeps turning off	See "Screen timeout" in section 17.
Something else looks wrong	Close Talanoa completely and open it again from its icon. If it still happens, take a photo of the screen and email it to Tim Broussard at tcdeveloper@gmail.com .

17 Looking after the phone



Charge every night

A flat battery means a resident with no voice.



Volume

Use the side buttons while Talanoa is talking to set how loud it is.



Screen timeout

On most Android phones: **Settings** → **Display** → **Screen timeout**, and choose a longer time (for example 10 minutes).



Clean and protect

Wipe the screen with a slightly damp cloth. A sturdy case is a good idea.



Loud places

A small clip-on Bluetooth speaker makes the voice easier to hear in shops and cars. Show it big helps too (section 8).



Emergency information

Set it up once, so first responders can see it on the lock screen (section 8).

18 Asking for changes

New words, different wording, a real photo of someone instead of a picture: the family can add these. Write down what's needed (for example *"add Swing, 'I want to go on the swing'"*) and pass it to **Tim Broussard**. The change reaches the phone automatically, usually the same day. Settings → **Most-used pictures** can help decide what to add.

Tim Broussard

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19 Credits & contact

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Talanoa Staff Guide · <https://tcdeveloper27.github.io/Talanoa/manual/>